



APT36 UNLEASHES GO-BASED MALWARE AGAINST INDIAN GOVERNMENT LINUX SYSTEMS

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A new cyber-espionage campaign launched by **APT36** (also known as Transparent Tribe) marks a significant shift in the group's capabilities, targeting BOSS Linux, a distribution widely used by Indian government agencies. According to a CYFIRMA report, this Linux-specific operation employs **Go-based malware** disguised as a cybersecurity advisory to infiltrate and persist within sensitive government networks.

CAMPAIGN OVERVIEW

- **Initial Vector:** Phishing email impersonating a cybersecurity alert

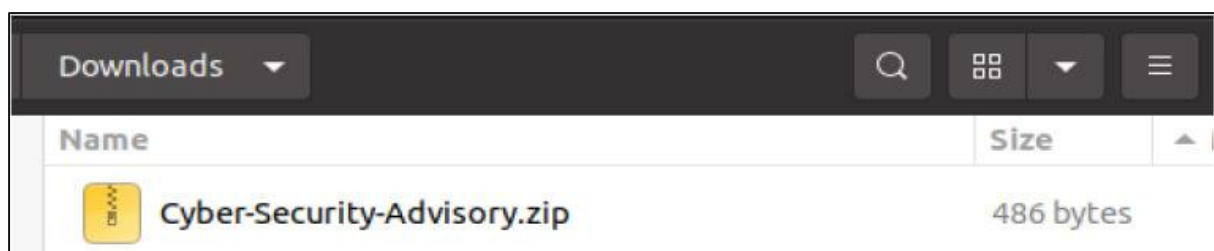


Figure 1: zip file obtained from phishing mail

- **Payload Container:** Cyber-Security-Advisory.zip containing a .desktop shortcut file

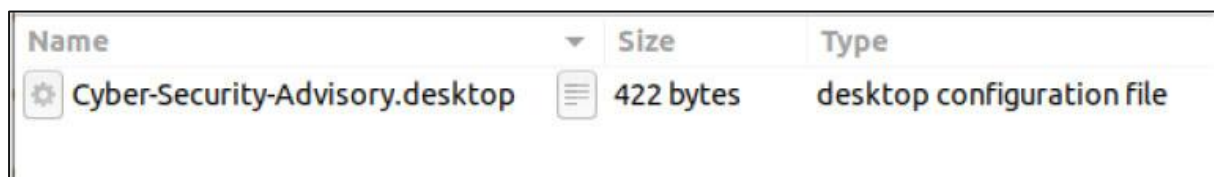


Figure 2: desktop configuration file inside zip file

- **Execution Flow:**
 - Opens a **decoy PowerPoint slide (slide.pptx)** using LibreOffice Impress
 - Silently drops and executes a **malicious ELF binary (client.elf)** using nohup
 - Output redirected to /dev/null for stealth

MALWARE CAPABILITIES

The Go-based binary performs several key espionage functions:

- **Reconnaissance:**
Collects hostname, CPU/RAM info, runlevel, and startup script details
- **Persistence & Stealth:**
Logs activity using main.junkcalc2, suppressing antivirus detection

- **Data Discovery & Theft:**

Uses os.readDir to search the file system and exfiltrates data via the main.sendResponse

- **Visual Surveillance:**

Captures desktop screenshots using Go's kbinani/screenshot library

- **C2 Communication:**

Contacts 101.99.92[.]182:12520 and maintains access with 30-second retry keep-alives

INFRASTRUCTURE & PARALLEL WINDOWS ACTIVITY

1. **Known Domain:** sorlastore.com – previously linked to APT36 operations
2. **Related Windows Attacks:**
 - Use of **malicious PPAM (PowerPoint Add-in) files** in phishing emails
 - Crafted to resemble defense advisories and cybersecurity bulletins
 - Mirrors Linux tactics: dual delivery (decoy + malware)

MITRE ATT&CK TECHNIQUES

Tactics	Techniques
Initial Access	Phishing (T1566) • Spear Phishing Attachment (T1566.001)
Execution	Scripting (T1064)
Persistence	Create or Modify System Process (T1543) Systemd Service (T1543.002)
Privilege Escalation	Create or Modify System Process (T1543) Systemd Service (T1543.002)
Defense Evasion	Scripting (T1064) Hide Artifacts (T1518) • Hidden Files and Directories (T1518.001)
Discovery	Software Discovery (T1518) • Security Software Discovery (T1518.001) Application Layer Protocol (T1071)
Command and control	Application Layer Protocol (T1071)

	Non-Application Layer Protocol (T1095) Ingress Tool Transfer(T1105) Non-Standard Port (T1571)
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INDICATORS OF COMPROMISE (IOCs)

File Hashes
608fff2cd4b727799be762b95d497059a202991eb3401a55438071421b9b5e7a ace379265be7f848d512b27d6ca95e43cef46a81dc15d1ad92ec6f494eed42ab e528799a29e9048c1e71b78223311cad2699d035a731d1a6664fc8ddd0642064 167b387005d6d2a55ad282273c58d1786a2ee0fa3e7e0cb361d4d61d8618ee5f
URLs
https://govin.sorlastore[.]com/uploads/Cyber-Security-Advisory.pptx https://govin.sorlastore[.]com/uploads/BOSS.elf https://govin.sorlastore[.]com/uploads/BOSS.elf http://169.254.169[.]254/latest/meta-data/ami-id
Domains
sorlastore[.]com modgovin.onthewifi[.]com
IP addresses
101.99.92[.]182 169.254.169[.]254

RECOMMENDATIONS

- 1. Harden Linux Security Posture:** Review .desktop file execution policies and implement strict file permission controls.
- 2. Monitor for IOCs:** Look for C2 connections to 101.99.92[.]182:12520 and suspicious .elf binaries (e.g., client.elf).
- 3. Email Filtering:** Deploy advanced phishing filters and sandboxing for ZIP attachments claiming to be security advisories.

4. User Awareness: Train users, especially in defense/government roles, to avoid opening unexpected .desktop files or add-ins.

5. Cross-Platform Threat Intelligence: Recognize that APT36 campaigns are expanding across both Windows and Linux environments—defenses must adapt accordingly.

REFERENCES

<https://securityonline.info/apt36-unleashes-linux-malware-transparent-tribe-targets-indian-government-with-go-based-espionage-tools/>
<https://www.cyfirma.com/research/phishing-attack-deploying-malware-on-indian-defense-boss-linux/>

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